

AI-Designed_Portrait_Guide_012

Difficulty Advanced

Est. time 10-14 hours

Subject Male Portrait with Visible Beard

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

• COLOR PALETTE

**90% Cool Grey****PC1067**

Dominant cool shadow foundation (29.3% of subject); base for cool shadows, eye sclera, core shadow undertones; anchors cool-toned zones

**Crimson Lake****PC925**

Warm dark red accent (14.5%); iris detail, mouth corners, warm undertones in deep shadows, beard warmth

**Copenhagen Blue****PC906**

Cool shadow blue (12.5%); core eye shadow, deep cool shadows in transitions, garment base, final punch-back

**Black****PC935**

Deepest dark (8.9%); pupils, upper lash line, beard core density, critical punch-back after burnishing

**Nectar****PC1092**

Warm peachy-brown (7.3%); mid-tone skin layer, nose structure warmth, transition areas

**Dark Brown****PC946**

Warm dark brown (6.4%); value block-in scaffold, beard texture, warm dark shadows

**Peach****PC939**

Warm light (6.2%); primary warm skin base layer, cheek highlights, nose tip glow, peak light accents



Chocolate

PC1082

Warm dark brown (5.5%); beard density core, value modeling, eyelid definition, punch-back detail



Henna

PC1031

Warm reddish-brown (4.7%); primary form modeling, beard graduated density, warm mid-tones



Carmine Red

PC926

Warm red accent (~4.7%); iris radial detail, tear duct warmth, mouth definition



Periwinkle

PC1025

Light cool blue-violet; cool undertone foundation for luminosity; optical mixing base



Light Cerulean Blue

PC904

Light cool blue; cool undertone glaze, eye sclera tone, luminous transitions



Cloud Blue

PC1023

Cool mid-light blue; cool undertone foundation, shadow zone glazing, soft cool transitions



50% French Grey

PC1072

Warm mid-grey; form modeling transitions, unification glaze base, warm blending vehicle



Slate Grey

PC936

Cool neutral grey; eye sclera, core shadow undertone, cool mid-value shadows



Beige Sienna

PC1080

Warm mid-tone; primary skin modeling, neck tone, transition areas between warm and cool



Terra Cotta

PC944

Warm burnt orange; primary form development, midtone deepening, warm shadow undertone



Salmon Pink

PC1001

Warm light pink; skin base unification, cheek highlights, luminous warm layer



Ginger Root

PC1084

Warm neutral-tan; nose structure, ear warmth, subtle skin transitions



Peach Beige

PC1085

Very light warm; peak highlights, bright light accents, final luminous notes



Cream

PC914

Warm very light; peak highlight peaks, burnishing vehicle, unification glaze



White

PC938

Absolute lightest; burnishing vehicle, extreme peak highlight (use sparingly on brightest point)



Light Umber

PC941

Warm light brown; final unification glaze, light warm transitions, softening pass



True Blue

PC903

Deep cool blue; deep shadow accents, punch-back detail layer



10% Cool Grey

PC1059

Very light cool grey; background tone, soft highlight transitions

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

SUBJECT IDENTIFICATION

What is the subject?

Male portrait, approximately mid-50s, medium-deep warm golden-olive skin tone with visible, well-developed beard. Head tilted slightly with frontal to three-quarter view orientation. Expression is neutral to serene. Dark short hair, dense beard especially at chin and jaw, with sparse beard texture on cheeks. Professional portrait quality with life and presence.

Material characteristics

Human skin exhibiting subsurface translucency (warm glow at nose tip, ears, and thin areas); visible facial hair demonstrating graduated density (dense at core, sparse at edges); warm golden undertones with cool shadow shifts; the surface reads as living, dimensionally complex skin, not flat or plasticky; beard shows individual hair structure rather than uniform mass.

Geometric structure

Head is spherical with cylindrical neck below. Key facial planes: frontal forehead (most lit), convex cheekbones (light-catching), protruding nasal structure (glowing warm), defined jaw with depth, eyes recessed in sockets with upper lid shadow, complex cartilaginous ears. The face tilts slightly; away-side (camera-left) shows gentle modeling through soft light rather than dramatic shadow. Strong three-dimensional form potential.

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

Soft, warm-toned frontal key light (likely soft studio or window light) positioned slightly above and forward of subject. No harsh single point source; rather diffuse, even illumination creating gentle modeling without dramatic chiaroscuro. Light is warm in temperature.

HIGHLIGHT

Forehead apex (center), bridge and tip of nose (warm glow from translucency), peak of cheekbones (convex light-catching surface). These are brightest zones but not extreme; overall image is mid-toned without severe highlight-to-shadow contrast.

LIGHT AREA

Upper face, temples, cheekbones, nose, upper lip, upper neck. These zones read as warmly lit, approximately mid to mid-light in value. No hard edge transitions.

MIDTONE

Majority of face: cheeks, lower nose, upper jaw, sides of face. Forms the primary visual mass and carries primary warm skin tone with subtle modeling.

SHADOW

Underside of jaw, core shadow where cheekbone turns from light to shadow (gentle, not harsh), upper lid shadows, sides of nose, away-side face plane. Shadows are notably gentler than typical dramatic portraits; they read as warm mid-value rather than dark darks.

CAST SHADOW

Soft self-shadow under jaw (neck-facing underside), subtle shadows within eye sockets, minimal external cast shadows from objects.

<i>Edge quality notes</i>	Soft light produces soft terminators (light-to-shadow boundary is gradual, diffuse). Cheekbone terminator is very soft. Upper eyelid shadow is relatively crisp (hard edge) due to thin lid structure. Hair-to-face edge is lost in most areas. Jaw-to-neck shadow edge is soft but defined. Background edge is lost and requires intentional diffusion during refinement.
COLOR ANALYSIS	
<i>Overall temperature</i>	Warm-dominant. Measured tones (Peach, Salmon, Henna, Sienna, Nectar) anchor palette firmly in warm range. Cool tones (Copenhagen Blue, Slate Grey, Cloud Blue) present for depth and luminosity, but visual weight is warm.
<i>Light zone tendency</i>	Warmth and saturation increase toward lit zones. Forehead, nose tip, cheekbone peaks, upper lip read warmest and lightest with peachy, salmon, golden undertones. Color becomes more saturated (higher chroma) in lit zones.
<i>Shadow zone tendency</i>	Shadows shift cooler (blue-grey, cool brown undertones) while remaining warm relative to pure cool—no grey or desaturated zones. Away-side face, eye sockets, core shadows read as warm mid-value with cool blue-grey undertones, not ashy or neutral.
<i>Special color areas</i>	Beard: dark warm brown to black with graduated density from core to edges. Eyes: dark translucent pupils surrounded by multi-hued iris (cool outer, warm inner) with cool-toned sclera. Lips: upper lip darker and more neutral-warm, lower lip lighter and more saturated warm, subtle red at corners. Nose tip: notably warm peachy-salmon (subsurface scattering effect).
<i>Saturation distribution</i>	Modest saturation overall; not vivid. Most saturated zones: cheekbone peaks, nose tip, lips. Least saturated: deep shadows, areas with strong reflected light (optically desaturated through mixing). Beard mostly desaturated (dark brownish-black) with subtle warm undertones.

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

01 Value Block-in and Structural Foundation

Entire face and neck; core light-shadow structure at light-to-medium value

Light-to-medium pressure circular strokes for blending; directional strokes following facial planes for form; multiple light passes building value gradually

Light to Medium pressure

Because the eye reads form primarily from value (lightness) separation rather than color, establish the full value range first at light-to-medium pressure before adding local color. Using Dark Brown and Chocolate at a very light hand, block in the core structure: identify peak light zones (forehead center, nose bridge and tip, cheekbone peaks), midtone planes (upper face, cheeks), the soft self-shadow under the jaw, and the gentle terminator (core shadow) where cheekbone turns from light to shadow. Work gradually in 3-4 passes rather than one dark layer to preserve paper tooth for color work ahead. Keep all values at medium-dark at this stage—deepest blacks come last. The reference shows soft frontal lighting, so keep shadows gentle and warm-toned, never hard or ashy. This scaffold establishes where value shifts occur without committing to final darkness.

COLORS ● PC946 Dark Brown ● PC1082 Chocolate

✦ *The most common mistake here is making the value map too dark too fast, crushing paper tooth before you've layered color. Treat this pass as a scaffold: establish WHERE shadows sit and how much value they hold, but keep them light enough that pencil strokes remain visible—you'll darken them across several color passes. Light hand now equals more layers later.*

02 Cool Undertone Foundation for Luminosity

Entire face, neck, and ears; cool glaze foundation under warm skin tones

Very light circular pressure for even coverage and optical blending with base layer; full-face unified pass; preserving paper tooth

Very Light pressure

Skin is translucent, and under soft warm light the core and reflected-light zones shift subtly cool to create luminosity. Apply a thin, even glaze of light cool tone (Periwinkle blended optically with the Dark Brown base) across the entire face and neck at very light pressure. This cool undertone sits beneath the warm skin tones you'll add next, creating an optical mix that reads fresher and more alive than warm alone. The cool undertone prevents shadow zones from reading flat or muddy. Work in one full pass across the entire area for evenness using circular strokes that preserve paper tooth. Pay special attention to shadow zones and the terminator area—the cooler undertone here is what makes those zones glow rather than look dead.

COLORS



PC1025 Periwinkle



PC904 Light Cerulean Blue

✦ *This is where many artists miss the principle of optical mixing—a thin cool glaze under warm tones creates saturation and glow that a single warm tone cannot achieve. It's not about making the face look blue; it's about the eye fusing the layers together into a luminous, living color. Optical mixing is the entire physics of colored pencil portraiture.*

03 Warm Skin Base Unification Across Entire Face

Full face, neck, and visible ear; primary warm color establishment at consistent value

Directional strokes following facial planes and bone structure; consistent pressure across full zone for unification; light to medium pressure maintaining pencil visibility

Light to Medium pressure

Now build the primary warm local color across the entire face in one unified pass before any local deepening or modeling. Using Peach or Salmon Pink at light-medium pressure, apply broad even strokes across the full face—lit planes, shadow planes, and transitions all receive the same warm mid-tone. This ensures the skin reads as one temperature family, preventing the patchiness that comes from rendering zone-by-zone. The warm tone optically blends with the cool undertone beneath, creating the natural golden-olive hue visible in the reference. Use long directional strokes following bone structure, not random circular marks. Leave no white paper showing in skin zones. This unification pass is counterintuitive—form comes next; unification first.

COLORS  PC939 Peach  PC1001 Salmon Pink

✦ *Building the entire skin zone in one pass at the same pressure and color sounds wrong when you want form, but it's the secret to avoiding blotchy, patchy skin. Form emerges from layering distinct hues over this unified base, not from rendering zone-by-zone. This is a professional technique: unification prevents the common failure of a face with isolated warm and cool patches that read as splotchy rather than luminous.*

04 Primary Form Modeling with Warm Mid-Tones and Earthy Hues

Entire face; building toward shadow and lit planes with warm mid-tones

Directional strokes on planes; light circular blending on transitions; form-aware pressure and color placement; mid-value restraint on away-side

Light to Medium pressure

Soft light still carries structure—the cheekbone is still a turning plane, the jaw still has depth. Model form across the full face using warm mid-tones and earthy hues. Using Sienna, Terra Cotta, and Henna, apply these tones in a second full-face pass, focusing them slightly more on midtone planes and shadow-receiving zones, but NOT yet the deep core shadows. Keep pressure light to medium and strokes directional (following facial planes). The goal is to deepen the midtones while preserving the warm base—you're optically layering warm-on-warm with slight temperature and value shifts, not jumping to dark darks yet. This pass reads like sculpting form, not filling it in. The away-side face plane begins to show depth but remains warm and mid-value, not dark.

COLORS



PC1072 50% French Grey



PC944 Terra Cotta



PC1031 Henna



PC1080 Beige Sienna

✦ *The temptation here is to jump to the darkest shadows on the away-side face, but resist: keep that plane warm and mid-value, not dark. A warm, mid-value away-side face reads as form turning in light; a dark away-side reads as a dark patch stuck on the cheek. You'll define the core shadow edge crisply in the next step, but the plane itself stays warm and light.*

05 Eyes – Blocking, Pupils, Upper Lid Shadow, and Sclera Tone

Both eyes; pupils, upper lid shadow, sclera, basic eye depth and form

Circular pressure for pupil; soft directional strokes for lid shadow; light uniform pressure for sclera; careful preservation of specular highlight location

Medium (pupil), Light (shadow and sclera) pressure

The eye is the window to form and life; block it correctly and the whole face reads present. Starting with the pupil: using Black or Deep Blue (a dark blue-black that reads translucent, not solid flat black), place the pupil as a dark circle, leaving a small white specular highlight undrawn (lightly mark its position to preserve paper). Cast a soft shadow from the upper eyelid across the top of the iris—this shadow is crucial for making the eye sit in the socket and read as deep. Now establish the sclera (white of the eye): it is NOT white—instead, apply light blue-grey (Slate Grey or Light Cerulean) at very light pressure to define the eye's shape and depth. The iris itself will sit between the pupil and lit sclera, creating form and dimension. This blocking establishes the eye's three-dimensional structure before detail work.

COLORS

● PC935 Black

● PC1067 90% Cool Grey

● PC936 Slate Grey

● PC903 True Blue

✦ *Many portraitists make the sclera pure white, which kills the eye's ability to sit in space and glow. A cool light grey sclera reads as lit and dimensional; pure white reads as a flat, empty circle. Reserve true white for a single small specular highlight at the top-outer edge of the pupil—that one bright point is all you need to make the eye live.*

06 Iris Detail, Radial Depth, and Multi-Hue Optical Mixing

Both irises; radial pigmentation structure and depth

Radial strokes from pupil outward; optical color mixing with distinct hues at different radial zones; light to medium pressure; short directional strokes

Light to Medium pressure

The iris is a complex structure with radial pigmentation that creates depth through color mixing. Working from pupil outward, use radial strokes in multiple warm and cool hues to suggest iris depth. Begin with a ring of warm ochre or sienna around the pupil, then layer cool blue-grey tones (Copenhagen Blue, Slate Grey) in the outer iris zone; add flecks of warm orange or red (Crimson Lake, Carmine Red) to suggest the living color variation found in real eyes. The goal is NOT to render every iris pattern, but to suggest depth and luminosity through multiple colors fusing optically. Use light-medium pressure and keep radial strokes short and directional, never a flat fill. The eye reads as a spinning disk with depth, not a flat colored circle. Multiple distinct hues optically mixed read alive; a single flat color reads dead.

COLORS



PC906 Copenhagen Blue



PC925 Crimson Lake



PC926 Carmine Red



PC942 Yellow Ochre



PC1072 50% French Grey

✦ *A common failure is rendering the iris as a flat circle of one color. Instead, think of the iris as a spinning disk of color—radial strokes and warm-cool alternation create the illusion of depth and light glint. The eye's life depends on multiple colors fused optically, not a single flat fill.*

07 Eyelids, Tear Ducts, and Lash Definition with Asymmetric Rendering

Upper and lower eyelids, inner and outer eye corners, lash lines

Sharp directional strokes for upper lash line; soft diffuse for lower; very light touch on tear duct; blending softly into surrounding skin at one edge only

Medium (upper line), Very Light (lower line and tear duct) pressure

The upper eyelid is darker and more defined than the lower; this asymmetry is crucial to eye realism. Using a sharp pencil and warm dark tones (Chocolate, Henna, or Carmine Red), draw the upper lash line as a crisp, dark shape following the natural lid contour—this is one of the sharpest, hardest edges in the whole drawing, commanding attention. Draw individual lashes or a soft lash mass that tapers toward the outer corner, never rigid or perfectly even. The lower lash line is much softer and more diffuse—apply it with very light pressure and warm-cool mixed strokes (no hard line, just suggestion). The tear duct (inner corner) receives a tiny warm touch of pink or red (Salmon Pink, Carmine Red) to suggest the moist mucous membrane; keep this small and subtle, not a bright blob. The asymmetry—sharp upper, soft lower—is what reads as real.

COLORS

● PC1082 Chocolate

● PC1031 Henna

● PC926 Carmine Red

● PC1001 Salmon Pink

✦ *The upper lash line is the single darkest line on the eye, and it's often the difference between a plastic eye and a living one. Make it a true dark, let it curve naturally with the lid contour, and crucially, do NOT mirror it on the lower lid. Asymmetry reads as real; perfect symmetry reads as artificial.*

08 Cheekbone and Mid-Face Form Development Through Value Hierarchy

Upper cheek, cheekbone peak, side of face toward ear; lit plane modeling

Directional strokes following the cheekbone's curve; light circular blending at transitions; value gradient from peak to recession; form-aware pressure modulation

Light to Medium pressure

The cheekbone is a light-catching convex surface, and in this reference it's well-defined. Using warm mid-tones and light tones (Peach, Salmon Pink, Light Peach Beige, or Ginger Root), build the lit cheek plane with a slight gradient from cheekbone peak (brightest) toward the ear (slightly deeper). The peak of the cheekbone catches the light and should be the lightest, warmest zone on the face after forehead and nose tip. Apply at light-medium pressure in directional strokes following the cheekbone's convex form, then blend softly into the adjacent shadow zone. The transition from lit to shadow must be gradual here (soft terminator) because the cheekbone is a rounded form, not a sharp plane. This is where form truly emerges through value hierarchy.

COLORS

- PC939 Peach
- PC1001 Salmon Pink
- PC1085 Peach Beige
- PC1084 Ginger Root

✦ *The cheekbone peak is where artists often miss establishing form through value hierarchy. Keep it lighter than the midtone, and use warm undertones (peachy, salmon) to suggest blood and life. A muddy or ashy cheek reads as exhaustion or illness; a warm, luminous cheek reads as alive and healthy.*

09 Core Shadow Placement and Warm Plane Separation – Critical for 3D Form

Away-side cheek, jaw; core shadow zone under the cheekbone on shadow-receiving side

Directional strokes placing core shadow crisply; soft circular blending on light side; directional for plane; deliberate mid-value restraint; asymmetric blending

Light to Medium pressure

This step is critical: the shadow side of the face must read as form turning in warm light, not a dark blob. Using warm mid-value tones (50% French Grey + Henna, or Sienna, or Beige Sienna base topped with warm undertones), place a defined core shadow where the cheekbone turns from light to shadow—this is the terminator. The core shadow is crisp and real, but kept at a MID-value (not heavy dark, not light), and warm in temperature. The shadow plane of the cheek itself (away-side face) receives a slightly deeper warm tone (Sienna, warm-grey, or warm-brown) but NEVER a dark ashy mass. This plane must read as turning away from light while remaining part of the warm-lit face, not a dark patch. Use light directional pressure and blend the core shadow edge softly into the midtone on one side while keeping it crisp on the terminator. Squint-test: if you squint and the shadow side disappears into darkness, you've gone too dark.

COLORS ☐ PC1072 50% French Grey ☐ PC1031 Henna ☐ PC944 Terra Cotta
☐ PC1080 Beige Sienna ☐ PC1023 Cloud Blue

✦ *The away-side plane is where many artists oscillate between flat (no shadow) and overcorrection (heavy dark hollow). The test is simple: squint and ask, 'Can I still see the cheekbone structure and warm tone on the shadow side?' If it disappears into darkness, you've overcorrected. Keep it warm and mid-value, and the form will read three-dimensional.*

10 Nasal Structure, Warmth, and Translucency Effect

Nose bridge, nose tip, nostrils, sides of nose; translucent warmth and structure

Soft directional strokes; very light pressure for bridge shadows; light circular pressure for tip glow; careful nostril suggestion with sharp pencil

Light to Medium pressure

The nose is a small protruding form that glows warm in any lighting because the tip is thin and light scatters through it (subsurface scattering principle). The bridge carries structure (subtle shadow lines on either side where it meets the cheek plane). Using warm mid-tones and light tones (Peach, Salmon Pink, Ginger Root, Nectar), establish the nose tip as the warmest zone—notably warmer and lighter than surrounding skin. The bridge carries subtle shadowing (very light use of cool undertones like Slate Blue or Periwinkle) on either side, but never heavy lines. Nostrils are small, dark, warm areas (Chocolate or Henna with light touch) but never pure black or harsh—they should suggest depth without looking like holes drilled in. The transition from nose to upper lip is slightly cool and soft. Keep pressure light and the nose unified with surrounding skin—it should read as part of the face, not a separate shape.

COLORS



PC939 Peach



PC1001 Salmon Pink



PC1084 Ginger Root



PC1092 Nectar



PC1082 Chocolate



PC1031 Henna



PC1023 Cloud Blue

★ *The nose is small, but it's where artists often abandon subtlety and overwork, creating harsh shadows or dark nostrils. A nose that glows warm and sits lightly on the face reads alive; a nose with harsh shadows reads over-rendered and unnatural. Keep it warm, keep it light, and trust the form to emerge from value and temperature shifts alone.*

11 Mouth and Lips with Asymmetric Value and Temperature

Upper and lower lips, mouth corners, surrounding mouth area; asymmetric color and value

Soft directional strokes following lip contour; very light pressure for creases; blending at edges; late-stage detail application for texture

Medium (upper lip), Light (lower lip), Very Light (creases and line) pressure

Lips have inherent form and color: the upper lip is darker, cooler, and more structured; the lower lip is lighter, warmer, and more saturated because it's the light-catching curved surface. Begin with the upper lip using a warm dark tone (Henna, Chocolate, or red-brown) at medium pressure, following the natural lip contour—this isn't an outline, but a filled shape. The lower lip, in contrast, should be lighter and warmer (Peach, Salmon Pink, or Light Peach) and slightly more saturated. The lip line itself should be soft and integrated into surrounding skin—avoid a hard outline that reads artificial. The mouth corners (where lips meet) carry subtle warm shadows (Henna or Crimson Lake) but these should be soft, not crisp. If the reference shows fine vertical texture creases on the lips, reserve these for the very end (after burnishing) with a sharp pencil and neutral or cool-warm tone at the lightest possible pressure. The asymmetry—darker upper, lighter and warmer lower—is what creates dimensionality.

COLORS  PC1031 Henna  PC1082 Chocolate  PC939 Peach
 PC1001 Salmon Pink  PC925 Crimson Lake

✦ *The most common lip mistake is making both lips the same value or temperature, creating a flat, dimensionless mouth. Real lips have asymmetry: the upper lip is darker and cooler (partly due to face structure shadow), while the lower lip glows warm and lighter because light catches its convex surface. Keeping them distinct in value and temperature creates form and life.*

12 Facial Hair – Graduated Density Beard Rendering

Beard and facial hair zones (chin, jaw, cheek, upper lip, neck); graduated from dense to sparse

Directional strokes following hair growth; graduated pressure (heavy core, light edges); sparse individual hairs at edges; sharp pencil for definition; asymmetric density

Medium (dense core), Light (sparse edges) pressure

This subject has clearly visible facial hair, and beard rendering must convey that it's hair growing from skin, not a shape stuck on. Hair density graduates: dense and dark at chin and core jaw, thinning to sparse individual hairs toward cheeks and edges. Build the beard in layers of graduated density. Start by placing the densest, darkest area (Black or Deep Brown) at the chin and jaw core in short directional strokes following growth direction (downward on chin, slightly outward on jaw sides). Then, moving outward and upward (toward cheeks and upper lip), reduce pressure and switch to lighter warm tone (Henna, Chocolate) with fewer strokes—individual hairs and gaps where skin shows through. On very edges and cheeks, use only a few light scattered strokes with warm tone, so you see mostly skin with sparse hair texture. The transition from dense to sparse must be gradual, not a hard line. Use a sharp pencil for individual hair strokes following natural growth direction. The beard is never uniform; it's a landscape of density variation. This graduated approach is the difference between a real beard and a glued-on dark blob.

COLORS

● PC935 Black

● PC1082 Chocolate

● PC1031 Henna

● PC925 Crimson Lake

● PC946 Dark Brown

✦ *Beard failure comes from rendering it as an even-density dark mass. Instead, think of it as hair distribution: the skin beneath is still visible where the beard is sparse, and the core (chin, jaw) is dense enough to read as a real beard. The graduated density is what makes it read as growing hair, not a shape stuck on the face.*

13 Ear Structure, Cartilage, and Integration with Head

Visible ear; helix, antihelix, lobe, ear canal, and color transition

Soft directional strokes for form; light circular blending for transitions; very light pressure for inner detail; careful soft edge integration

Light to Medium pressure

The ear is a complex cartilaginous structure with ridges and planes. Its color is typically warmer and slightly deeper than surrounding face because it receives less direct light and more reflected light from inside the ear canal. Block in the ear's basic form (outer helix, inner structures) using the skin-tone palette but warmed slightly—Peachy Beige, Henna, or Ginger Root at light-medium pressure. Define the inner ear structures (antihelix, tragus) with subtle shadows using cool-toned greys (Slate Grey, Cloud Blue) and warm darks (Chocolate, Dark Brown) placed lightly. The ear canal opening carries a hint of depth (very light use of deep cool tone or near-black) but avoid making it a harsh dark hole. Keep edges soft, especially where the ear attaches to the head. The lobe often glows warm and slightly translucent if backlit; suggest this with a touch of warm light (Peach, Salmon Pink).

COLORS

- PC1085 Peach Beige
- PC1031 Henna
- PC1084 Ginger Root
- PC936 Slate Grey
- PC1023 Cloud Blue
- PC1082 Chocolate
- PC946 Dark Brown

✦ Ears are often neglected, but an ear that reads as part of the head rather than a separate shape makes the whole portrait coherent. Keep the ear's value between the face and background (not as light as face, not as dark as background), and use color harmony—warm skin tones with cool shadow undertones, just like the face. The ear is a microcosm of the whole portrait's color strategy.

14 Neck Modeling and Jaw-to-Neck Transition – Mandatory 3D Integration

Neck and jawline; transition from face to neck; soft self-shadow under jaw

Directional strokes following the neck's cylindrical form; soft shadowing for jaw underside; gentle blending at face-to-neck boundary; color temperature shift for depth

Light to Medium pressure

The neck is a continuation of the face but typically cooler and slightly deeper in value. This mandatory step establishes three-dimensional form and prevents the head from looking pasted onto the body. Establish the neck's basic form (cylindrical, tilting slightly with head position) using the skin-tone palette (Peach, Salmon, Beige Sienna) at light pressure, slightly cooler and deeper in value than the face. The underside of the jaw (the soft self-shadow created by the jaw's projection over the neck) must have a gentle but real shadow—using cool-warm mixed darks (Cloud Blue base + Henna, or Slate Grey + Sienna) at light-medium pressure, create a crisp but soft shadow line where the jaw meets the neck. This shadow line should curve with the jaw's form, not be a straight hard line. The transition between face and neck should be soft; blend the face's skin tone into the neck's slightly cooler tone gradually over 3-4 strokes rather than an abrupt edge. The sides and back of the neck, if visible, may carry reflected light (touch of warm) or shadow (cool-warm blend).

COLORS

● PC939 Peach

● PC1001 Salmon Pink

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

● PC1023 Cloud Blue

● PC1031 Henna

● PC1072 50% French Grey

● PC936 Slate Grey

✦ *A neck that reads as a separate, disconnected shape kills the portrait's coherence. Make the neck a natural continuation of the head and face by using a color temperature shift (slightly cooler) and a soft but real shadow under the jaw, so the viewer sees the jaw as a form projecting over the neck, not a line floating on top. This one step transforms a disconnected head into an integrated head-and-neck form.*

15 Garment Color, Texture, and Edge Integration

Jacket, collar, shoulders, and edge where garment meets neck and face

Directional strokes following fabric folds and weave; light pressure for reflected light; soft edges where garment meets skin; simple, unobtrusive coverage

Medium (garment base), Light (reflected color and edges) pressure

The garment anchors the portrait and can bounce color onto the lower face and neck. From the reference, the jacket appears to be a dark blue or dark neutral color. Using cool darks (Copenhagen Blue, 90% Cool Grey, Slate Grey, or nearly Black), establish the garment's local color at light-medium pressure. Suggest fabric texture through subtle directional strokes following the fabric's weave and folds—not every stitch, but the general drape and structure. Where the garment meets the face/neck, ensure the edge is soft and integrated; a hard edge looks artificial. If the garment is dark, it will reflect very little light, but place the smallest touch of warm highlight on the highest (most lit) point of the shoulder or collarbone to show it's a three-dimensional form. The garment should be rendered simply and quickly—it's supporting the face, not the focus. If there's subtle reflected light from the garment onto the underside of the chin or lower neck, add a touch of cool reflected color (a whisper of the garment's hue) at very light pressure.

COLORS



PC906 Copenhagen Blue



PC1067 90% Cool Grey



PC1023 Cloud Blue



PC935 Black



PC1001 Salmon Pink

✦ *The garment is easy to over-render. Remember: it's background to the face. A few directional strokes suggesting fabric structure, dark value established early, and careful soft edges are all you need. Over-detailing the garment pulls attention away from the portrait's center and wastes effort on supporting elements.*

16 Background and Negative Space Establishment

Area surrounding the subject; wall, air, or other background elements

Light, even pressure; soft directional strokes for subtle variation; simple, unobtrusive coverage; preserving negative space clarity

Very Light pressure

A simple, neutral background lets the subject breathe and hold focus. Using a neutral warm or cool grey (50% French Grey, Cloud Blue, or light Slate Grey), establish the background at very light pressure across the entire background area. Keep it simple and unobtrusive—this is not a detailed environment, but a complementary space that recedes. If the reference suggests a specific background color or value, match it lightly. The edge where the subject's profile (hair, ear, shoulder) meets the background should eventually be softened and may carry a hint of atmospheric perspective (slightly cooler or more diffuse than subject). For now, block it in simply; refinement comes with edge work later. Avoid any background that's too dark, which will compete with the face and pull focus.

COLORS



PC1072 50% French Grey



PC1023 Cloud Blue



PC936 Slate Grey



PC1059 10% Cool Grey

✦ *A background that's too detailed or too dark competes with the face. A simple, cool-neutral background makes warm skin pop and keeps attention centered. If you're unsure, err toward simplicity—a quiet background is the professional choice.*

17 Peak Highlights and Light Accents – Hard Value Jumps for Illumination

Forehead apex, bridge of nose, nose tip, cheekbone peaks; any light-struck surfaces commanding attention

Deliberate, light-medium pressure placement; hard edge between highlight and adjacent midtone; soft blend into surrounding tone on one side only; sharp value jump

Light to Medium (highlights), Very Light (white, if used) pressure

This step directly addresses the loop correction: the brightest lights must reach a true peak and create a hard value jump from the surrounding midtone, so the face reads as struck by light, not evenly filled. Using Cream or very light Peach (PC1085 Peach Beige, PC914 Cream) at light-medium pressure, place warm highlights on the forehead center (the apex where light hits first), the bridge and tip of nose (which glows warm even in shadow), and the peak of cheekbone (the light-catching convex surface). These highlights should be notably lighter than surrounding midtone and sit directly adjacent to a slightly darker midtone, creating a hard but small edge that reads as light reflection, not a soft blend. On the nose tip especially, if the reference shows a true specular peak, add a touch of near-white (very light Cream or barely-visible white pencil) as the absolute brightest point. This peak-highlight step is NOT optional—it transforms the face from a filled form into a lit form.

COLORS



PC914 Cream



PC1085 Peach Beige



PC939 Peach



PC938 White

✦ *The difference between a portrait that looks painted and one that looks illuminated is the peak highlight. A soft, diffuse highlight reads as evenly lit and flat. A small, clear peak highlight with a hard value edge reads as light striking the form. Place it decisively and resist the urge to diffuse it away completely—that hard edge is what sells the illumination.*

18 Final Unification Glaze, Edge Refinement, Burnishing, and Bloom Correction

Entire face, neck, garment; selective edge work; burnishing and punch-back detail

Very light glazing strokes for unification; selective edge softening and hardening; heavy burnishing pressure for smooth finish; sharp-pencil detail last at very light pressure; punch-back with medium pressure on darkest darks

Very Light (glaze), Heavy (burnishing), Medium (punch-back), Very Light (final detail) pressure

The final pass unifies color temperature, desaturates any harsh edges or blotchy areas, and prepares for burnishing. Apply a thin, even glaze of neutral or very light warm grey (Light Umber, 50% French Grey, or a whisper of Cream) across the entire skin area at very light pressure. This glaze harmonizes the layers beneath, softens any remaining color clashes, and creates optical unity. While the glaze dries, refine edges: soften and lose the background edges (hair-to-background, ear-to-background) by feathering or diffusing them slightly, while keeping focal edges (upper lash line, highlight edges) crisp. Once satisfied, burnish the smooth areas (face, neck) using a colorless blender or white pencil at HEAVY pressure—burnishing melts the layers into a polished, painted finish. CRITICAL CORRECTION: Burnishing lightens values, so after burnishing, punch back the darkest darks (pupils, lash lines, core shadows, beard dense areas) using fresh applications of Black, Copenhagen Blue, or Chocolate at medium pressure. This wax-bloom correction is MANDATORY, not optional—without it, the burnished face will look pale and washed out. Finally, add any final razor-sharp details (individual lashes, fine beard hairs, skin texture) using a very sharp pencil with dark tones at the very lightest pressure, only after burnishing and punch-back are complete.

COLORS

● PC941 Light Umber

● PC1072 50% French Grey

● PC914 Cream

● PC938 White

● PC935 Black

● PC906 Copenhagen Blue

● PC1082 Chocolate

✦ *Burnishing is the final stage, but many artists stop there and end with a flat, pale face. The wax bloom correction—punching the darks back up after burnishing—is what separates a professional portrait from a tired-looking burnished drawing. It's a separate, deliberate step: identify the deepest darks (pupils, lash lines, beard dense areas, core shadow edge) and press fresh dark pigment into them at medium pressure, creating crisp definition in a smooth, burnished field. This is how you get both luminosity AND depth—the signature move of professional portraiture.*